

Financial data sources: what we can freely use

Research note for Virtual Gold · September 2026

Three questions: what is freely usable, what licence does it carry, and which dataset has answers we can score against.

Public source data (the "public" layer of the vertical scenario)

Source	What it gives us	License / access	Notes
SEC EDGAR	Real 10-K, 10-Q, 8-K filings, any public company	Public domain, no license, government publication	Free API, but requires a descriptive User-Agent header with a real contact email or it blocks the request; unofficial rate limit around 10 req/s.
Yahoo Finance (via <code>yfinance</code>)	Daily price history, any ticker	No official license, unofficial/undocumented endpoint	Not sanctioned by Yahoo for redistribution, tolerated for research use, not for a commercial product. Fine for this capstone.
Alpha Vantage	Daily price history, any ticker	Free tier, documented terms	Cleaner licensing story than Yahoo if that ever matters, but needs a free API key and is rate-limited (5 calls/min, 500/day). We used <code>yfinance</code> since it needs no signup; switch here if Yahoo ever becomes a blocker.

Finance QA benchmarks (the "accuracy_benchmark" batch, scorable ground truth)

Dataset	License	Ground truth	Size / content	Fit
FinanceBench	CC BY-NC 4.0 (non-commercial)	Yes, gold answer plus justification plus evidence citation	150 examples, built from real 10-K/10-Q/8-K filings (3M, Adobe, Amazon, and others)	Good content fit, real filing-grounded questions, but the non-commercial license is a real constraint if any of this ever reaches Virtual Gold's production system after the capstone, not just the class deliverable.
FinQA	MIT	Yes, gold reasoning program and gold execution result, not just a bare answer	Numerical reasoning over financial report tables and text	Recommended. Fully permissive license, no commercial restriction at all, and the ground truth is more rigorous than a plain answer string, we can score both the final number and whether the reasoning steps hold up.
TAT-QA	CC BY 4.0 (attribution required)	Yes, test-set ground truth was released in a 2024 update, held back before that	16,552 questions over 2,757 hybrid table-plus-text contexts from real financial reports	Permissive and large, viable second choice if FinQA's table format doesn't fit our harness cleanly.

Recommendation

Use **FinQA** as the accuracy_benchmark source. MIT license means zero licensing risk for the team or the client, and its reasoning-program ground truth lets us score more than just "did the model get the number right", we can check whether it reasoned correctly. Pull a small labelled sample (not the full set) and score against FinQA's gold execution result.

Keep FinanceBench in reserve: if the team ever wants filing-grounded questions with human-written justifications specifically (closer in style to the vertical trading scenario than FinQA's table-heavy questions), it's usable for the class deliverable, just flag the non-commercial license before it goes anywhere near a client handoff.

One licensing note

FinanceBench's CC BY-NC 4.0 license is fine for coursework but would need to be swapped out (for FinQA or TAT-QA) if any evaluation code or data built on it is expected to carry forward into something Virtual Gold uses commercially. Worth a one-line mention in the client email so this isn't a surprise later.